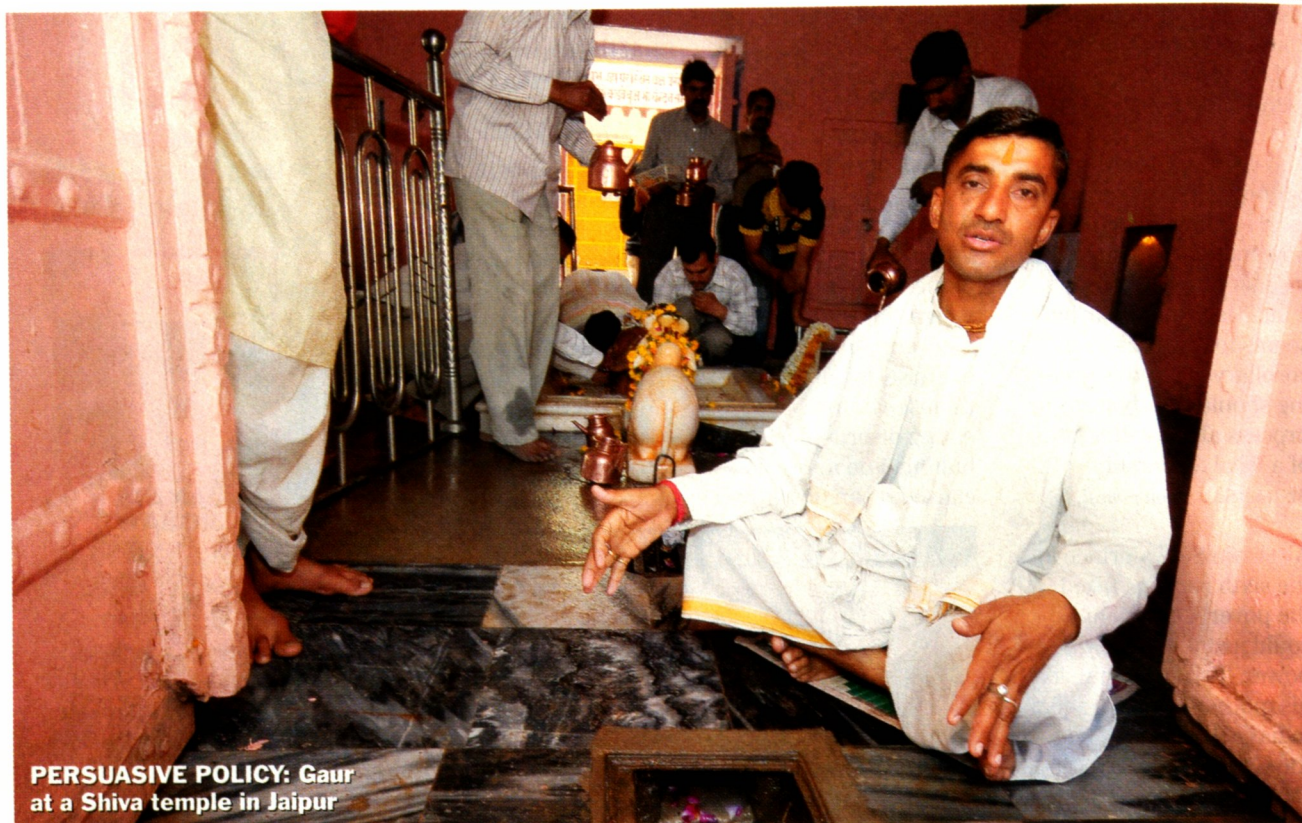




PERSUASIVE POLICY: Gaur at a Shiva temple in Jaipur

Worshipping Every Drop

In a unique way, an astrologer harvests water used in temples, saving crores of litres during the monsoon

■ By Rohit Parihar

Lord Shiva may not be too pleased with the idea of thousands of litres of water going down the drain in a water-starved state like Rajasthan, even though the exercise is meant to appease Him. In Jaipur, devotees bathe Shiva idols and lingas in temples with over 50 lakh litres of water every day during the monsoon. A devotee uses a thousand two-litre pitchers to “bathe” the linga. If a family of five joins in the ritual, it alone accounts for the waste of 10,000 litres. With over 700 such lingas in the city being cleansed by thousands of devotees daily, the wastage of water is staggering.

Alarmed by this, Purushottam Gaur of Ved Villa Colony, Mansarovar, in Jaipur thought of harvesting the water. In 2001, the 41-year-old astrologer started getting 30-ft pits dug where the water from the idols was routed into. He also dug a separate 5-ft deep pit for the milk offerings. Prior to this, the water and milk used to flow out unchecked to open areas near temples, creating puddles that stank amid unhygienic conditions. The areas around temples also became breeding grounds for mosquitoes and flies. “In Jaipur alone, crores of litres are used during the rains,” says Gaur. Families end up wasting their entire month’s



requirement of water in just one ritual, often buying water tankers.

In seven years, Gaur has persuaded 250 temples in the city to adopt his method, which includes harvesting rain water on rooftops. In some of the older temples, the water is redirected to dry wells instead of a pit. In Civil Lines, it has resulted in the recharging of a dead borewell at a Shiva temple.

But it has not been easy. Gaur’s efforts were initially suspected by some priests as a means to garner popularity and demand a right to worship. Even when his followers began donating money for the cause, most priests were reluctant to adopt the project, which costs just Rs 2,500 each.

Gaur admits that spreading awareness about his programme won’t be quick as it needs personal interaction and persuasion “This needs to be done all over the country, not just in Jaipur,” he says. Ground water experts say that since temples are located at a distance from each other, such harvesting does not provide instant results. However, it does improve the water table in the immediate vicinity. Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje wants priests to motivate devotees to incorporate water harvesting in colonies as well. With global warming being a burning issue, Gaur’s methods may well go a long way in appeasing Lord Shiva. ■